

Beyond Easy Language

Designing AI-Simplified Easy Finnish News with Immigrant L2 Learners

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This study investigated how generative AI can be used to redesign Easy Finnish news so that it fulfils prospective readers' diverse linguistic and information needs, focusing on immigrant L2 learners as the target demographic. Adopting a participatory approach, we worked with a group of university students who are learning Finnish as a second language to identify how their needs are served by current easy language news offerings. Based on their insights, we developed new AI features for the regional newspaper Helsingin Uutiset, which the participants got to test over a two-week period.

Why this matters

Easy Language is a format designed for people who find standard language too difficult to follow. By the end of 2018, the Finnish Centre for Easy Language (*Selkokeskus in Finnish*) estimates that Easy Finnish serves roughly 11–14% of the population of Finland (*Selkokeskus*, 2019), including, among others, people with learning disabilities and memory-related conditions, as well as those learning Finnish as a second language. Because readers' informational, cognitive, and linguistic needs often pull in different directions, Easy Language is always a compromise, and no single format can serve everyone equally well.

Immigrants consume news from various sources, including mainstream and alternative media from the host societies, international outlets, and media from their countries of origin (Mahtani 2008; Shumow 2010). Easy Language news serves these readers only for a short window: roughly between the A2 and B1 phases. Beyond that, learners land in a limbo where easy news has become too simple, yet standard news is still too complex to follow without linguistic or contextual support.

Generative AI opens a way to meet these varied needs. In a previous study that also used articles from Helsingin Uutiset and other local newspapers from the capital region, Maukonen et al. (2025) found that news simplified by large language models did not differ in comprehensibility from Easy Finnish

articles written by journalists, and that targeted simplification based on reader demographics increased engagement.

Research participants

Thirteen Finnish learners, students from a university-level Finnish language course, plus two pilot participants, answered an initial survey on their Finnish news-reading experience in March 2026. A one-hour classroom discussion with participants then shaped which AI features we would build. In April, participants received the prototype together with a design probe: a digital news-reading diary. During two weeks, the participants used the diary to record their day-to-day news-reading experience on the platform, keep notes about the news they read, and review the two AI-aided features. Seven diaries were returned. The probe let us observe how the features entered participants' everyday news-reading routines.

Easy Finnish landscape today

The official guidelines for Easy Finnish, overseen by *Selkokeskus*, cover text structure, information content, grammar and vocabulary, even images and graphical layout (*Selkokeskus*, 2026). In practice, the format is a compromise between the contradictory interests of different reader demographics. To better cater to different readers, researchers have proposed dividing Easy Finnish into three levels by the degree of text difficulty (Leskelä, 2021).

In Finland, Easy Language news has been recommended to L2 learners as learning materials (Kielibuusti, 2024). *Selkokeskus* publishes *Selkösanomat*, which publishes simplified versions of news from several publications. The Finnish Broadcasting Company, *Yle*, also produces its own Easy Finnish news. The *Keskisuomalainen* media concern publishes 'Helppoa suomea' articles, which are not certified by *Selkokeskus*, for capital-region readers. They are written directly in a simpler format rather than simplified from existing articles, often by writers with immigrant backgrounds, and aimed at

Finnish L2 learners. In Helsingin Uutiset, whose articles were used in this study, we found these

‘Helppoa suomea’ articles to be on average somewhat easier than the regular articles, though the difficulty of individual articles varies significantly.

Feature	Yle Selkouutiset	Selkösanommat	Helppoa suomea	NHK News Web Easy	Todaii Japanese	Asagaku Plus	RFI Français facile	Lingvis	Our prototype
Difficulty labelling	—	—	—	—	✓ Per-news article and Word-level	—	✓ Per-news article (CEFR)	✓ User-preset (CEFR)	Reader- selected (CEFR)
Same article at several levels	—	—	—	—	—	—	— No one-to-one mapping between a news item and all levels	✓ Simplifies based on preselected level, with info-loss notice	✓ A2 / B1 / B2 / original
Link to original article	—	—	—	✓	—	—	—	✓ via ‘Original’ button	✓ built-in as a level
Topic categorisation	—	✓ categorized by theme	✓ All news articles can be filtered by keyword	—	✓ categorized and can be filtered by theme	✓	✓ categorized by theme	—	✓ All news articles can be filtered by keyword
Vocabulary support	—	✓ Dictionary + translation tools	—	✓ Glossary + Furigana reading aid	✓ Full word list + pop-ups + bilingual translation + Furigana reading aid + on-demand any-span explanation	✓ Glossary for key terms	✓ Glossary for key terms	✓ Translation (native language) + Predictive dictionary	✓ On-demand, any-span explanations
In-text color coding	—	—	—	✓ proper noun colours	✓ JLPT-level colours	—	—	✓ by users’ familiarity	—
Audio support	✓ audio / video	✓ adjustable speed	—	✓ audio / video	✓ adjustable speed	—	✓ audio with synchronized transcript	✓ adjustable speed + synchronized translation	—
Exercises / quizzes	—	—	—	—	✓	—	✓	✓	—

Table 1. Learner-support features across benchmarked platforms and our prototype

What other platforms already do

For Finnish, we reviewed four platforms offering easy-language news: Yle Selkouutiset, Selkosanomat, Selkosanomat kuvilla, and Lingvis. Yle Selkouutiset offers approximately four to five easy-language news stories per day, accompanied by audio or video reporting. Selkosanomat, published by Selkokeskus, covers Finnish and international current affairs, updated continuously online, with 200-500 stories a year, and lets readers listen to the news and use integrated dictionary and translation tools; the kuvilla version supplements the text with illustrating images.

Lingvis, a language-learning application published by the Lingvis foundation, is aimed particularly at supporting refugees and migrants in language integration, and comes closest to our approach in the prototype. In articles labelled 'simplifiable', users click a magic wand icon and then 'Simplify' to generate text matching their preselected Finnish proficiency level, with an 'Original' button to return to the standard-language text, and a notice at the end warning of possible alteration or loss of information. Like Helppoa suomea by Helsingin Uutiset (HU), the simplified news on Lingvis is not certified by Selkokeskus as Easy Language content.

Internationally, we benchmarked Japanese (NHK News Web Easy, Asagaku Plus, Todaii Japanese) and French (Le français facile avec RFI) platforms. Every platform offers reading aids and signals text difficulty, but at varying granularity.

Only Lingvis generates simplified text on demand and only at the user's single preselected level. We observed that no platform offers the same article at several selectable difficulty levels. Based on the discussions with our participants, we designed our prototype to allow the reader to toggle between versions and compare them against the original.

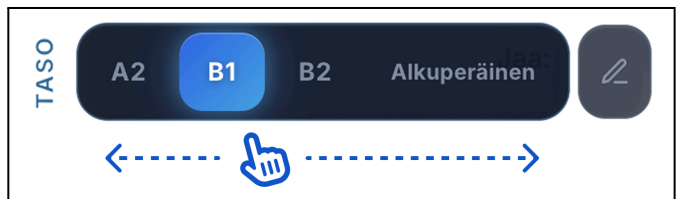
What we built

We developed a prototype news platform that replicates the reading environment of Helsingin Uutiset's Helppoa suomea section and adds two AI-aided features derived from participant feedback: a language level selector and a highlighter to assist L2 learners in reading Finnish news.

The level selector

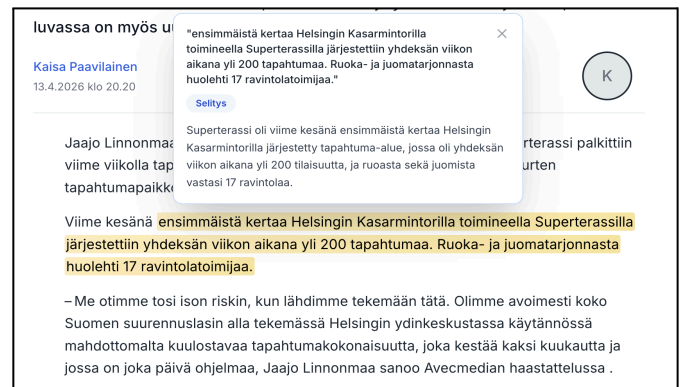
The level selector offers four versions of each article: A2, B1, B2 and the original, with the three simplified

variants generated by the large language model GPT-5.4. Similar to what easy language researchers, such as Leskelä (2021) had proposed, we wanted to extend the range of typical Easy Finnish into both directions, creating easier and more complex variants of the simplified content that would roughly correspond to the CEFR levels A2 and B2, with the original Easy Finnish -level content staying in-between, around B1 level. Since the versions share a common paragraph structure, the readers can easily consult the original article when needed without losing their place.



The highlighter

The highlighter generates personalized explanations for any span of text: a single term, a phrase, an entire sentence or a whole paragraph. Under the hood, the LLM is given the full article as context, and depending on context, can give either a grammar-, vocabulary-, or content-related explanation of the highlighted section according to the reader's selected proficiency level.



Automated Article Simplification

The LLM adapts each article to the target CEFR level based on difficulty scores it receives from a separate classifier model. This is then followed by a 'critic' stage, during which the LLM edits the article based on feedback it receives from another LLM. This critic LLM is prompted with 40 criteria selected from the Easy Finnish Indicator published by the Finnish Centre for Easy Language. Two Finnish teachers reviewed simplified articles during development.

What participants told us

What holds readers back today

When analysing the survey results and the classroom discussions we had with the participants, we observed that their challenges cluster into four interrelated factors:

- vocabulary and grammar
- unfamiliar cultural and social contexts
- cognitive load
- lack of engaging content

These rarely act alone; a reader can understand every word of a story and still miss its point for lack of context. Their motivations were similarly layered: reading to learn the language and understand society, but also out of genuine interest, rather than in any single fixed mode.

Next, we analysed whether the features we developed helped to address any of these issues.

The level selector

Almost all participants switched between levels to observe differences between versions, to assess their own comprehension, and to settle on a level most compatible with them. Readers used version comparison itself as a strategy: starting at B2 and dropping to A2 when 'something was confusing', or escalating to the original when 'something felt strange or unclear'.

"It is good that we can choose the language level ourselves."

— Study participant, reading diary

The negatives were real, too: some participants noted that the difficulty level of the text was lower than expected, information was sometimes lost to the point of obscuring what actually happened, phrasing could be odd or repetitive, and some advanced readers (B2 level) found the original clearer or more informative than the simplification. Interestingly, most errors the readers observed were not due to the LLM misbehaving, but were actually a result of the Easy Finnish Guidelines it was following. Despite these, the level selector feature was well received by the participants, especially for how it preserved readers' agency and lowered the threshold for reading in the second language.

The highlighter

Use of the highlighter varied more widely, serving two overlapping purposes: language-focused learning (e.g., unfamiliar vocabulary and word inflexion) and comprehension support (e.g., the meaning of whole sentences or sub-clauses and the context of local news). For vocabulary, the highlighter's usefulness depended on the reader's existing Finnish proficiency; those with a larger vocabulary found explanations 'almost always clear', while others said it often rephrased the sentence using the very words they did not understand. For contextual information, it rarely helped, because news stories often cover new topics, and therefore the LLM had no prior knowledge of it outside what was already mentioned in the article.

"This was hit-or-miss."

— Study participant, reading diary

Participants suggested the following improvements for the feature for their unmet needs:

- multilingual translations/synonyms/simpler sentences for vocabulary support
- grammar explanations
- options to choose the topic of an explanation
- saving highlighted words for later review.

What we found

Our results show that generative AI can help mitigate some of the problems that our participants had when engaging with Finnish news. Its value lies in offering readers multiple degrees of simplification, all accessible and personalisable on demand. Readers moved fluidly between the A2, B1, B2 and original versions, often comparing the same passage across levels to check their own comprehension. Generating explanations on demand for any passage a reader selects proved more mixed: it handled vocabulary well but struggled with cultural or background gaps, since its only context was the article itself. Above all, generative AI's value here is that it turns difficulty from a fixed property of the text into a control held by the reader, thus widening the range of news an L2 learner can actually read while keeping the original always within reach.

What this means for newsrooms

For a newsroom hoping to reach L2 learners, our study points to a few concrete lessons. The topic has to be relevant to readers' lives, not just content assumed to interest immigrants; several participants wanted 'real, current issues', not repeated stories about language learning or moving to Finland. Ideally, all news should be accessible in easy language, not a selected subset, and all content should be free. Indeed, one of the main benefits of AI is that it can allow everything to be simplified instantly.

Our results also show that L2 learners are no less oblivious to the risks and issues inherent to AI-generated content than native speakers. Readers should always be able to reach the original article: many treated it as the ground truth, switching to it when a simplified version felt strange or unclear. The one-click access to the original therefore enhanced the readers' trust in the content.

While working together with the intended readership is important for all easy language content, our findings show that the preferences of our demographic can vary on an individual basis. Simplification always has trade-offs: for example, lowering the level of vocabulary will often result in the loss of accuracy, and adding explanations makes texts longer. For newsrooms considering using AI for simplified texts, we want to stress the importance of giving the readers control over the simplification process.

The full research paper, "*Beyond Easy Language: Designing AI-simplified Easy Finnish News with Immigrant L2 Learners*", is forthcoming.

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